

The New-age Napster

Napster has changed its revenue model yet again. Now, subscribers pay a monthly fee to access the catalogue. Napster said mid-October that it is launching a Web-based platform that will make Napster compatible with any Internet-enabled device.



"YouTube Video Identification"

YouTube recently launched a copyright-protection system for content owners in which they could send in a master copy of their work, and any infringing videos relating to that content could be taken off the site if requested. The filter has received mixed reviews.



Enter



Vinay Goel
Head of Products
Google India

The Google SMS service has been launched in India. You can now send directory-like search queries to Google via SMS from any handset—find a pizza outlet near Peenya, Bangalore, by sending an SMS to 54664 with the query: "pizza near Peenya Bangalore"! We asked Vinay Goel of Google India about related issues.

Will you extend the service to smaller cities too? By when?

For now we're focusing on Bangalore, Delhi, Hyderabad, and Mumbai, because users here will have the fullest access to information through the service. Google SMS is also available in other cities, but not all the search categories will be immediately available. As we get more user feedback, we will add more cities.

Any tie-ups to report?

Google SMS is currently available on the Airtel, Aircel, BPL, BSNL, and Reliance networks.

Apart from saving locations, will the service store personally identifiable information?

It will, as outlined in our Mobile Privacy Policy—which can be found at our Web site. Users can opt out of personalisation by sending "Save off" to 54664.

Any plans for a Web directory service—like AnyWho.com, for example—for India?

We have also launched Google Local Search and Local Business Center as a part of our efforts to help users find locally relevant info. This includes listings of local businesses (movie theatres, ATMs, restaurants, etc.), weather forecasts, and more. Local Business Center allows business owners to add/edit their business information for free using a Web interface—www.google.com/local/add—so their listings are easily found by users.

DRIVING LINUX

Dumping The Linux Device Driver Kit

Every newbie who installed Linux came to know of it the hard way—Linux needs stable, working drivers for tons of peripherals. The current answer to this is the Linux Device Driver Kit—documentation designed by the Linux kernel community for hardware manufacturers. Manufacturers could also choose from the nearest drivers and reverse-engineer them to work with the hardware.

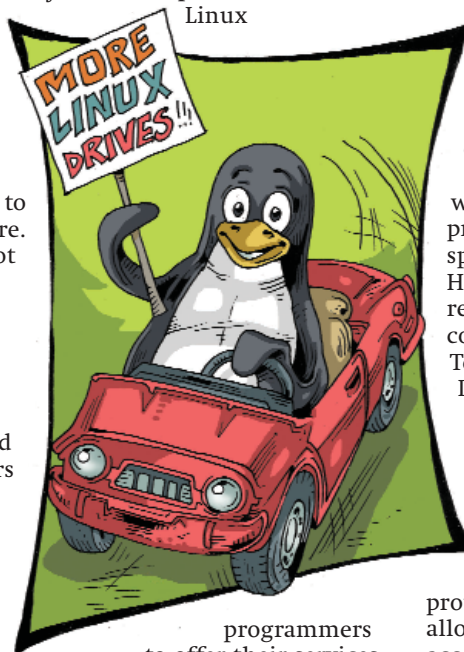
This process was not always fruitful. Considering its small user base compared to Windows, not many companies were interested in dabbling with Linux drivers. And then, hardware vendors have been wary of opening up their device designs or Application Program Interface (APIs) to the open source community. Another obstacle is the fact that most companies do not favour drivers they didn't develop themselves.

Now, a project from Novell is offering to write free drivers—for any manufacturer who is willing to open up the specifications of their hardware.

It's not a new project—it was announced last year by the main developer, Greg Kroah-Hartman, a programmer at Novell. But

mid-October, Kroah-Hartman posted an update on his blog, announcing that Novell had moved him onto the project full-time.

Kroah-Hartman is an influential Linux kernel hacker; his original blog post called on Linux



programmers to offer their services for free to any company that wanted to write Linux-compatible drivers for their products. He also proposed that all that was required from the companies was the specs, and perhaps a technician who could be frequently e-mailed when help was needed. He requested sample devices so that debugging didn't have to be done over e-mail. And what would the manufacturers get in return? A fully-functional

Linux driver that is added to the Linux kernel resource tree, and which is updated with every kernel revision.

Dangling the marketing carrot, Kroah-Hartman went on to say that since the drivers would be included in the Linux kernel, it would be supported by the largest number of CPU types in the history of computing!

For manufacturers wary of sharing their protocols and specifications, Kroah-Hartman clarified that if required, companies could approach the Linux Tech Board to draft Non Disclosure Agreements (NDAs) for the programmers working on the drivers.

Companies that were earlier apprehensive of showing their proprietary protocols were now allowing programmers full access to their APIs under the NDAs. Kroah-Hartman and his team are willing to sign NDAs for the actual details of the devices that the companies give out, all the code generated will be licensed under the GPLv2. Manufacturers therefore wouldn't even need to worry about supporting the drivers; the community would take care of that (since the drivers would be incorporated in the kernel).

Some Linux community members are apprehensive,